nancial freedom," says Bilqueesa Jan, DDC chairperson in Shopian. "Now, we are established stakeholders in the region's development." Her Baramulla counterpart Safeena Beigh calls this change "long overdue", accusing legislators of historically resisting the empowerment of PRIs.

Congress MLA Nizamuddin Bhat, however, dismisses comparisons between DDCs and MLAs as misguided. "Legislators are the creation of the Constitution, while DDCs are the creation of legislation," says Bhat. "MLAs have a broader role and mandate."

RIFT WIDE OPEN

- **The absence of MLAs from R-Day events in a few districts exposed their growing tensions with District Development Council members**
- **While newly elected MLAs struggle without Constituency Development Funds, DDCs constituted in 2020 wield financial power, fuelling a broader turf war**

Amid these tensions, legislators are pinning their hopes on the Omar government's first budget to revive CDF allocations. DDCs, meanwhile, have gained further momentum with the reintroduction of the Pradhan Mantri Jan Vikas Karyakram, enabling them to approve major works alongside deputy commissioners.

With the term of DDCs set to end in December, sources say, fresh elections for them are being considered along with the long overdue panchayat and municipal polls in May-June 2025. At a time when the Omar government is engaged in its own struggle with New Delhi for the return of statehood, this clash between grassroots empowerment and traditional authority underscores a pivotal moment in J&K's democratic evolution. ■

KERALA

SHIFTING EZHAVA GOALS

By Jeemon Jacob

The Ezhavas in Kerala are an unhappy lot. The politically active Other Backward Class community makes up 23 per cent of the population, but say they are being marginalised in the state. Traditionally part of the Communist voter base, Ezhava loyalties are now divided after their social organisation, the Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana (SNDP) yogam, floated a political outfit, the Bharath Dharma Jana Sena (BDJS), in 2015 and tied their political fortunes to that of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in the state. Having failed to make the expected gains, the Ezhava vote is now split across Kerala's three political fronts—the Left, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) and the NDA.

The widespread disaffection came to a head in late January when the BDJS passed a resolution to explore "alternative political partnerships". This was followed by a signed editorial by long-time SNDP chief Vellappally Natesan in their mouthpiece, *Yoganadam*, on February 1 praising chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan for ensuring Kerala's development, and blasting the Congress and BJP for their 'pathetic' treatment of Ezhavas. Soon after, though, his son and BDJS chief Thushar Vellappally clarified that the party wasn't snapping ties with the NDA. "It's all media speculation, they have projected the discussions within the party forums out of proportion. We are an integral part of the NDA in Kerala," Thushar told INDIA TODAY.

So what's really going on? Party analysts say the BDJS is looking for the best vantage position before the 2026 assembly poll. It did abysmally in the 2021 assembly polls and the 2024 parliamentary election, which means this could be its last shot at staying relevant in Kerala politics. As Ezhava leader and senior lawyer C.K. Vidyasagar points out, "We are not a homogeneous community. No Ezhava leader commands respect as most of them act for their own benefit. If the BDJS is snapping ties with the BJP, it is for the benefit of the Vellappally family and not to save the community," adding that "the dynamics within the community are changing; the youth are not ready to be part of vote-bank politics".

That said, sources say "political undercurrents" are strong as the assembly poll in 2026 nears. With anti-incumbency a big factor against his government, CM Pinarayi (an Ezhava himself) needs all the help he can get. Any overt support from the BDJS will be more than welcome. ■



SNDP chief Natesan's editorial praised CM Pinarayi Vijayan and the Left...and blasted the Congress and ally BJP for their 'pathetic' treatment of Ezhavas